Asking questions or admitting confusion

Practical guide for students | D07-ST

A focused question helps your teacher understand where you need support. You do not need to explain everything perfectly before asking.

1. Identify where you lost understanding

Try to locate the particular word, step, instruction or connection that is unclear.

Ask yourself: “What do I understand so far, and where does the difficulty begin?”

2. Choose an available way to ask

Check how your teacher invites questions. You might ask during a pause, speak after class, use a question box or discussion board, or arrange a consultation.

If speaking publicly feels difficult, use an available private or written route. For an immediate task, ask early enough to help you begin.

3. Explain what you understand

Give your teacher a starting point:

- “I understand the first step, but I’m unsure what happens next.”
- “I can follow the calculation, but I don’t understand why we use this formula.”
- “I understand the definition, but I’m not sure how it applies here.”

4. Ask for the help you need

Choose a request that matches the difficulty:

- Repetition: “Could you repeat the last instruction?”
- A different explanation: “Could you explain that another way?”
- An example: “Could you show an example?”
- A connection: “How does this relate to the previous point?”
- A check: “Does this mean that…?”

5. Check the explanation

After your teacher responds, briefly explain your understanding or try the next step.

“So, we compare both options before choosing one. Is that right?”

If you are still unsure, say which part remains unclear. You can point to a sentence, diagram or part of your work.

6. Use the answer

Apply the clarification to the task. Add a short note if you will need the explanation later.

If the same difficulty keeps returning, discuss it with your teacher and ask what further practice or support would help.

7. Example

Situation You can calculate a café's revenue and profit, but you do not understand how they can move in different directions.

A focused question "I understand how to calculate revenue and profit separately. What I don't understand is how revenue can increase while profit falls. Could you show that with some figures?"

Checking the answer "So, if the extra costs are greater than the extra revenue, profit falls. Have I understood?"

8. Check your question

- I have identified the part that is unclear.
- I have explained what I understand so far, where possible.
- I have asked for a useful explanation, example or check.
- I have checked whether the answer resolves my difficulty.
- I know what to do next.

If you cannot identify the exact difficulty: bring the task or material and show where you became stuck. You can say, "I'm not sure which part I've misunderstood. Could we look at this step together?"

9. Supporting sources

University of Minnesota, College of Continuing and Professional Studies. (n.d.). Listening. Open resource

Supports identifying an unclear part, requesting repetition or an example, checking an interpretation and seeking further help when understanding remains incomplete. See "While Listening" and "After Listening".

University of Minnesota, College of Continuing and Professional Studies. (n.d.). Participating in class. Open resource

Supports asking for further explanation, clarification of meaning or an example, and preparing questions for individual consultations with an instructor. See "Asking Questions in Class" and "Office Hours".